Numbers to know

THE NUMBERS THAT COME UP MOST

Typical stopping distances (dry road)	20 mph: 12 m · 30 mph: 23 m · 40 mph: 36 m · 50 mph: 53 m · 60 mph: 73 m · 70 mph: 96 m
Gap to the vehicle in front	At least 2 seconds on faster roads and in tunnels; at least double that on wet roads; on icy roads stopping distances can be up to 10 times longer
National speed limits (mph)	Cars and motorcycles: 30 in built-up areas, 60 on single carriageways, 70 on dual carriageways and motorways (unless signs show a lower limit)
Car towing a caravan or trailer	50 mph on single carriageways; 60 mph on dual carriageways and motorways; not in the right-hand lane of a motorway with 3 or more lanes
Drink-drive limit (England and Wales) England & Wales	35 µg per 100 ml of breath · 80 mg per 100 ml of blood · 107 mg per 100 ml of urine
Drink-drive limit (Scotland) Scotland	22 µg per 100 ml of breath · 50 mg per 100 ml of blood · 67 mg per 100 ml of urine
Minimum tyre tread depth (cars)	1.6 mm across the central three-quarters of the tread, all the way round
First MOT	When the car is 3 years old
New drivers	6 or more penalty points within 2 years of passing: licence revoked
Using a hand-held phone while driving	£200 fine and 6 penalty points
Child car seats	Until the child is 12 years old or 135 cm tall, whichever comes first
Passing a cyclist	Leave at least 1.5 metres at speeds up to 30 mph, more at higher speeds
Passing a horse rider or horse-drawn vehicle	At no more than 10 mph, leaving at least 2 metres

DRAFT

Speed limits and stopping distances

NATIONAL SPEED LIMITS (MPH)

TYPE OF VEHICLE	BUILT-UP AREAS	SINGLE CARRIAGEWAYS	DUAL CARRIAGEWAYS	MOTORWAYS
Cars, motorcycles and car-derived vans	30	60	70	70
Cars towing caravans or trailers	30	50	60	60
Motorhomes up to 3.05 tonnes unladen	30	60	70	70
Motorhomes over 3.05 tonnes unladen	30	50	60	70
Buses, coaches and minibuses up to 12 m long	30	50	60	70 (60 if over 12 m)
Goods vehicles up to 7.5 tonnes	30	50	60	70 (60 if articulated or towing)
Goods vehicles over 7.5 tonnes (England and Wales)	30	50	60	60
Goods vehicles over 7.5 tonnes (Scotland)	30	40	50	60

These are national maximums: a lower limit shown on signs always applies.

In Wales the default limit on restricted roads (usually with street lights) has been 20 mph since 17 September 2023.

TYPICAL STOPPING DISTANCES (DRY ROAD)

	THINKING DISTANCE	BRAKING DISTANCE	OVERALL
20 mph	6 m	6 m	12 m (40 ft)
30 mph	9 m	14 m	23 m (75 ft)
40 mph	12 m	24 m	36 m (118 ft)
50 mph	15 m	38 m	53 m (175 ft)
60 mph	18 m	55 m	73 m (240 ft)
70 mph	21 m	75 m	96 m (315 ft)

DRAFT

SOURCES The Highway Code, Rules 124, 126, 163, 215 and Annex 6 · GOV.UK, Drink-drive limit, MOT, penalty points, mobile phones, child car seats